Response to Reviewers

Reconnecting Trigger–Target: Awaken Backdoor Attacks in Knowledge-Distillation-Based Federated Learning

Journal: IEEE Transactions on Cloud Computing **Manuscript ID:** TCC-2026-08-0669

Dear Editor and Reviewers,

Thank you for your careful evaluation of our manuscript and for your constructive comments. We have carefully revised the manuscript and provide point-by-point responses below. For clarity, each reviewer comment is reproduced in a gray box, our response follows it, and the corresponding revised manuscript text is shown in a blue-accented box when appropriate.

The major changes in this revision are summarized as follows:

- Describe the first major change here.
- Describe the second major change here.
- Describe the third major change here.

We believe these revisions have improved the clarity and technical quality of the manuscript. We appreciate the opportunity to submit this revised version for further consideration.

Sincerely,
The Authors

Response to the Editor

Editor's comment: [Paste any specific editorial instruction here. If there is no substantive editorial comment, delete this section.]

Response: [Describe how you have addressed the editorial instruction.]

Responses to Reviewer #1

Comment R1.1. *[Paste Reviewer 1's Comment 1 verbatim here.]*

Response:

We thank the reviewer for this helpful comment. [State clearly what was changed, why, and how the change addresses the concern.]

Location in the revised manuscript: Section [X], Page [X], Lines [XX–XX]

> **Revised text:**
> [Paste the exact revised sentence(s) or paragraph from your manuscript here.]

Comment R1.2. *[Paste Reviewer 1's Comment 2 verbatim here.]*

Response:

[Provide a specific, evidence-based answer. If an experiment was added, refer to the corresponding table or figure and summarize its key finding.]

Responses to Reviewer #2

Comment R2.1. *[Paste Reviewer 2's Comment 1 verbatim here.]*

Response:

[Your response to Reviewer 2, Comment 1.]

Location in the revised manuscript: Section [X], Page [X], Lines [XX–XX]

> **Revised text:**
> [Exact revised manuscript text.]

Responses to Reviewer #3

Comment R3.1. *[Example only: The related-work discussion should focus more specifically on backdoor attacks in knowledge-distillation-based federated learning (KD-FL).]*

Response:

We appreciate the reviewer's suggestion. We have revised the related-work subsection to focus specifically on backdoor attacks in KD-FL, rather than backdoor attacks in conventional parameter-aggregation-based federated learning. We also clarify how these KD-FL studies relate to the threat model and mechanisms considered in our work.

Location in the revised manuscript: Section II-B, Page [X], Lines [XX–XX]

> **Revised text:**
> [Insert the exact new KD-FL backdoor related-work paragraph here, including the relevant citations.]